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Stone altar

4.2.1 Stone altar

References:

Hebrew מִזְבֵּחַ (mizbeach) GEN 8:20, GEN 8:20, GEN 12:7, GEN 12:8, GEN 13:4, GEN 13:18, GEN 22:9, GEN 22:9, GEN 26:25, GEN 33:20, GEN 35:1, GEN 35:3, GEN 35:7, EXO 17:15, EXO 20:24, EXO 20:25, EXO 20:26, EXO 21:14, EXO 24:4, EXO 24:6, EXO 32:5, EXO 34:13, NUM 23:1, NUM 23:2, NUM 23:4, NUM 23:4, NUM 23:14, NUM 23:14, NUM 23:29, NUM 23:30, DEU 7:5, DEU 12:3, DEU 27:5, DEU 27:5, DEU 27:6, DEU 33:10, JOS 8:30, JOS 8:31, JOS 9:27, JOS 22:10, JOS 22:10, JOS 22:11, JOS 22:16, JOS 22:19, JOS 22:19, JOS 22:23, JOS 22:26, JOS 22:28, JOS 22:29, JOS 22:34, JDG 2:2, JDG 6:24, JDG 6:25, JDG 6:26, JDG 6:28, JDG 6:28, JDG 6:30, JDG 6:31, JDG 6:32, JDG 13:20, JDG 13:20, JDG 21:4, 1SA 7:17, 1SA 14:35, 1SA 14:35, 2SA 24:18, 2SA 24:21, 2SA 24:25, 1KI 3:4, 1KI 12:32, 1KI 12:33, 1KI 12:33, 1KI 13:1, 1KI 13:2, 1KI 13:2, 1KI 13:2, 1KI 13:3, 1KI 13:4, 1KI 13:4, 1KI 13:5, 1KI 13:5, 1KI 13:32, 1KI 16:32, 1KI 18:26, 1KI 18:30, 1KI 18:32, 1KI 18:32, 1KI 18:35, 1KI 19:10, 1KI 19:14, 2KI 11:18, 2KI 11:18, 2KI 11:18, 2KI 16:10, 2KI 16:10, 2KI 18:22, 2KI 21:3, 2KI 23:12, 2KI 23:12, 2KI 23:15, 2KI 23:15, 2KI 23:16, 2KI 23:17, 2KI 23:20, 1CH 21:18, 1CH 21:22, 1CH 21:26, 1CH 21:26, 2CH 14:2, 2CH 23:17, 2CH 23:17, 2CH 28:24, 2CH 30:14, 2CH 31:1, 2CH 32:12, 2CH 33:3, 2CH 33:15, 2CH 34:4, 2CH 34:5, 2CH 34:5, 2CH 34:7, ISA 17:8, ISA 19:19, ISA 27:9, ISA 36:7, JER 11:13, JER 11:13, JER 17:1, JER 17:2, EZK 6:4, EZK 6:5, EZK 6:6, EZK 6:13, HOS 8:11, HOS 8:11, HOS 10:1, HOS 10:2, HOS 10:8, HOS 12:12, AMO 2:8, AMO 3:14, AMO 3:14

Greek βωμός (bomōs) ACT 17:23, 1MA 1:47, 1MA 1:54, 1MA 2:23, 1MA 2:24, 1MA 2:25, 1MA 2:45, 1MA 5:68, 2MA 10:2

Greek θυσιαστήριον (thusiastērion) ROM 11:3, JAS 2:21

Description and usage:

Flat altar made of uncut stones (© Ray Pritz by United Bible Societies)In Old Testament times, especially before the Tabernacle or the Temple was made, stone altars were built in the open air for the purpose of making sacrifices. The altars were made from large stones, piled together to form a platform. The sacrifices were of sheep or goats, or of offerings of grain. The stones used to make Israelite altars were not to be cut or shaped with iron tools (EXO 20:25; DEU 27:5).

Translation:

Circular Canaanite altar found at Megiddo (© Ray Pritz by United Bible Societies)Some languages may distinguish between natural stone and blocks that are the result of cutting and shaping. Where the stones of the altar are mentioned, translators should choose a word for natural stones.

If sacrificing animals is something that is done in the receptor-language culture, then consider whether there is some cultural equivalent for an altar. A number of modern cultures have elevated structures for sacrificing animals or for offering gifts to a deity. Sometimes this will be a stone or wood platform or table. Be sure that the translation makes it clear that the sacrifice is being offered to God.

A descriptive equivalent of "altar" occurs in some languages as "place where gifts are given to God." Several other models are "place/platform/hearth where people offer sacrifices," "bed/platform for [killing and] offering sacrifices," and "[hearth] stones for/of sacrificing things." In some contexts it may be necessary to add a phrase such as "where sacrifices are burned to God" or "where incense is burned to honor God." Other possible translations include "thing on which [sacred] offerings are placed" and "place of sacrifice." In most passages the actual form of the altar is not in focus; the important fact is that it was a place where sacrifices were made.

Warning: In some South American languages a transliterated form of "altar" (or its Spanish or Portuguese equivalent) may occur. This word is often "borrowed" with a restricted meaning, sometimes referring to the shrine of a particular saint, or to the front section of a church, or to a patriotic shrine. When a borrowed word of this kind occurs, always check carefully what meaning it has for speakers of the receptor language in order to know whether or not it is suitable.

Similarly, translators may be tempted to use a transliteration of the word "altar" because that is what is used locally in the Roman Catholic, Anglican, or other church. As in the case of the term "priest," it is recommended that this Christian term not be used as the basis for Old Testament translation, because it has a very different theological significance. See also 4.7 Cult place, high place<REALIA:4.7>.